years at court would have been deeply satisfying ones for a man who had dedicated his life to the cause of the Mughal Empire. In April 1586, Bhagwant Das's daughter gave birth to a child, a girl who was named Shah Begum, and Akbar called for celebrations which were unprecedented. Abu'l Fazl tells us that 'contrary to the usage', Akbar gathered an assembly to give thanks for the joyful news of the birth of a daughter. A great feast was hosted by Hamida Banu, who had come to court for the occasion, and gifts and money were distributed to all.

That Akbar had specifically ordered grand celebrations for the birth of a girl child was not surprising. His own daughters were raised with a great deal of love and preference, which Salim recalled with something akin to jealousy. 'Her temperament is greatly inclined to volatility and sharpness,' wrote Salim about his youngest sister, Aram Banu Begum, born just a few years before his own daughter. 'My father loved her so much that he politely tolerated her acts of rudeness, and in his blessed sight, since he loved her so much, she did not seem so bad. He often said to me,' continued Salim, who had clearly found his sister trying, 'Baba, for my sake, after I'm gone, treat this sister of yours, who is, as the Indians say, my ladla…as I do. Tolerate her coquettishness and overlook her rudeness and impudence.' Of another of his sisters, Shakr un-Nisa Begum, born after the birth of Daniyal in 1572, Salim notes the particular care Akbar took to keep her close to himself. 'Since she was brought up in the lap of my exalted father's care, she turned out very well,' wrote Salim, 'good-natured and innately compassionate toward all people.'

As his daughters and granddaughters grew up around him Akbar became increasingly concerned about the plight of girls when they got married and left their families. Criticizing Muslim laws of inheritance which allowed for a smaller share of inheritance to a daughter, Akbar argued that this was inherently faulty, for if a daughter was deemed 'weaker', then 'the weakness of the woman calls for a larger share', to ensure her own protection. As for the law which allowed a greater share of inheritance to fall to nephews in case a deceased person only had daughters, 'how could this law be justified', exclaimed Akbar. In this clear and lucid articulation of his disapproval of Muslim laws of inheritance with regard to girls, Irfan Habib considers Akbar a pioneer and a unique example of a sixteenth-century Muslim monarch wanting to safeguard the rights of girls and women through the reform of laws.